Beshalach 5785

Many years ago, during my ישיבה days, someone provided me with a large number of R' Avigdor Miller tapes, covering the whole year. I started listening to them during the summer, and I was hearing about בראשית and other topics that weren't relevant to that time. Despite this, I found him so interesting that I continued to listen attentively. Now, years later, I realize that all these tapes, all the topics, and the entire Jewish year are interconnected, all emanating from a single source. So, when I discuss פרשת בשלח and connect it to על הנסים from חנוכה, it's not as disparate or jarring as one might initially think.

The pasuk in פרשת בשלח says (14:14): ה' יִלָּחֵם לָכֶם וְאַתֶּם תַּחֲרִשׁוּן. Rashi comments: בִּשְׁבִילְכֶם, meaning that Hashem will fight for you. What does רש"י mean?

There's a גוואַלדיק vort on this pasuk from R' Beryl Weisbord in the Chanukah sefer put out by ישיבת נר ישראל, titled ה' יִלָּחֵם לָכֶם. He raises an intriguing question: In the נוסח of על הנסים, we praise Hashem for delivering גִּבּוֹרִים בְּיַד חַלָּשִׁים, רַבִּים בְּיַד מְעַטִּים, טְמֵאִים בְּיַד טְהוֹרִים, רְשָׁעִים בְּיַד צַדִּיקִים, and זֵדִים בְּיַד עוֹסְקֵי תוֹרָתֶךָ. The first two instances, גִּבּוֹרִים and רַבִּים in the hands of חַלָּשִׁים and מְעַטִּים, represent supernatural נסים. However, the last three seem to be natural outcomes we would expect when engaging in תורה and מצוות, that Hashem will give us הצלחה in what we do. Where is the נס in these?

R' Beryl brings down a רמב"ן at the beginning of פרשת וישלח, where יעקב prepared for three things: תפילה, דורון, and מלחמה. Was יעקב truly preparing for a literal battle? The רמב"ן explains that he was preparing to engage in a battle as a means to escape. This highlights the Jewish approach to מלחמה: ה' יִלָּחֵם לָכֶם, ה' אִישׁ מִלְחָמָה. כלל ישראל are not natural warriors; it is Hashem who fights for us. Any battle in which we engage is merely a means to escape, with Hashem doing the real fighting.

In על הנסים, we thank Hashem for נִסִּים, פֶּרְקָן, גְּבוּרוֹת, תְּשׁוּעוֹת, and מִלְחָמוֹת. Interestingly, מִלְחָמוֹת is mentioned last. This emphasizes that our gratitude extends beyond נסים הטבע מן למעלה to every single thing, פֶּרְקָן, גְּבוּרוֹת, and תְּשׁוּעוֹת that happens to us on a daily basis. As the רמב"ן writes, a person does not have a חלק in תורת משה until he believes that all of our activities, everything that we do our entire lives, is a נס. There is no טבע, only Hashem's direct involvement.

In עַל הַנִּסִּים, חז"ל emphasized that the הצלה was בדרך מלחמה, but the fact of the matter is, the נִצָּחוֹן of the מלחמה was not because of the efforts of "The mighty Maccabim", as all the songs go, but rather only because of ה' איש מלחמה. Even though they put on battle armaments and were working with swords, bows and arrows, they did not win because of their heroics, but rather because of הקדוש ברוך הוא's activities.

Now we understand that even though we had a נצחון, and the נצחון was through נסים and נפלאות, it only was because of טְמֵאִים בְּיַד טְהוֹרִים וּרְשָׁעִים בְּיַד צַדִּיקִים וְזֵדִים בְּיַד עוֹסְקֵי תוֹרָתֶךָ. מלחמה is successful only because ה' יִלָּחֵם לָכֶם וְאַתֶּם תַּחֲרִשׁוּן. When רש"י says בִּשְׁבִילְכֶם, he means that if you're succeeding, understand that the cause of your success is Hashem. Here in בשלח, that's obvious. The splitting of the ים סוף, going through the ים, and drowning the מצריים was without human input. But even when it seems that something happens because of what we call טבע, we have to understand that it is also Hashem. In fact, the אזנים לתורה says (14:31): וַיַּרְא יִשְׂרָאֵל אֶת הַיָּד הַגְּדֹלָה אֲשֶׁר עָשָׂה ה' בְּמִצְרַיִם. Which was the greater of the two נסים? The splitting of the sea and כלל ישראל



https://youtu.be/jFjk65d0kG4

going through it, with water standing up, or, the waters falling back down and drowning the מצריים? The pasuk says בני ישראל saw what happened בְּמִצְרַיִם. The pasuk is telling that the טבע of gravity, and the טבע that water drowns people is exactly the same ניסים נפלאות as למעלה מן הטבע. That's what they understood, and that's what it means, בִּשְׁבִילְכֶם - ה׳ יִלָּחֵם לָכֶם, Hashem is doing everything for us. וְאַתֶּם תַּחֲרִשׁוּן - We do have to do our השתדלות. But because we do our השתדלות, let us not think for one second that it is our efforts that caused us to be successful; rather, everything we accomplish is only because Hashem wants us to.

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